



Communist threat

Kennedy points to a map of Southeast Asia at a press conference in March 1961, to illustrate the communist threat to Laos, Vietnam's neighbor. However, Kennedy rejected US intervention in Laos.

KEY CONCEPT

THE DOMINO THEORY

In the early 1950s, American foreign policymakers became firm believers in the Domino Theory: if communism was allowed to take hold in one nation, neighboring countries would also fall under its influence, each one knocking over the next, until they had all fallen. President Eisenhower referred to the theory as his rationale for intervening in Vietnam, while Presidents Kennedy and Johnson later used it to justify increasing US involvement in the conflict.

» AFTER

Kennedy and his advisers came to believe that the authoritarianism of President Diem was part of the problem, not the solution, in South Vietnam.

CHANGES AT THE TOP

In November 1963, Kennedy and his advisers covertly backed an **ARVN coup** and the installation of a military junta in South Vietnam.

Within three weeks, Kennedy had been **assassinated** in Dallas, Texas. Lyndon Johnson was immediately sworn in as president.